

ANGEL ACTION · MEDICAL

Diabetic Emergencies

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Hypoglycaemia (low blood sugar)

Signs: weakness, sweating, trembling, hunger, confusion, headache, slurred speech, irritable behaviour.

If conscious and able to swallow:

1. Give **sugar** — soft drink (not diet), juice, jelly beans, glucose tablets.
2. Repeat every **15 minutes** until they recover.
3. Follow with a longer-acting carbohydrate (sandwich, biscuit).
4. If no improvement, **call 000**.

If unconscious: call 000, follow **DRSABCD**, place in **recovery position**. Do NOT give anything by mouth.

Hyperglycaemia (high blood sugar)

Signs: excessive thirst, frequent urination, nausea, fruity breath, drowsiness — develops over hours or days.

- Follow **DRSABCD**.
- Help them with their own insulin if they ask.
- **Call 000** if their condition is worsening or they become drowsy.

When in doubt, give sugar

If you are unsure whether it's a hypo or a hyper, give sugar. It will help a hypo and will not significantly worsen a hyper in the short term.

Adapted from Australian First Aid 5th Edition. Get the full guide and live CPR metronome at firstaidangel.org.